Thursday 5 November: Loch Ness to the Enchanted Forest

Dry and cold. About 3°C at 10:00 and 5°C at midday at Fort Augustus. About 9°C at Pitlochry in the afternoon, then 5–6°C for the forest, feeling like 3°C. Light wind, no rain forecast. Sunset 16:23 at Pitlochry. This is the 3 November forecast, so check it again.

The day

- **By 09:45** Leave Bluebell. Check-out by 10:00.
- **09:45** Drive to Fort Augustus, about 70 min plus lights. Open in Maps
- **About 10:55** The locks and the Loch Ness shore (the walk below).
- **About 12:00** Lunch, Lock Inn, Canalside, Fort Augustus. Open in Maps
- **13:00** Leave. Drive about 118 min: A82 to Spean Bridge, A86, A889 to Dalwhinnie, A9 south.
- **About 15:00** Fonab Castle, Pitlochry. Booking.com 5051820619, check-in from 15:00. Open in Maps
- **About 16:00** A proper snack for Noah.
- **16:50** Leave for Fishers Hotel, about 10 min. Parking there isn't confirmed, so allow time.
- **17:15** ✅ Check in at Fishers Hotel, Pitlochry, PH16 5BN, for the Enchanted Forest bus. Open in Maps
- **About 19:45–20:00** Back at Fishers (from the trip notes).
- **About 20:00** Dinner idea: Fonab's 1892 Grill. Not booked yet.

To do

- **Book dinner:** 1892 Grill, Fonab, 01796 470140 or online. Service is 18:00–21:00. Ask for a table about 20:00 and whether there's a children's menu.
- **At check-in:** confirm the bed or cot for Noah.
- **Enchanted Forest e-ticket:** See Tickets order 130768425. Have it on a phone to scan. The 17:15 on the ticket is your check-in time for the bus. Tickets aren't refundable. The file is saved as `tickets/enchanted-forest-thu5-1715-order-130768425.pdf`.
- **Wear** warm layers, hat and gloves for the forest.
- **Tired Noah fallback:** room service at Fonab, 24 hours, plus a £15 tray charge.

Roads (Traffic Scotland, read about 07:00 on 3 November)

No daytime closure was listed on today's route, but there are a lot of lights. Allow 15–20 min extra each drive, which is my estimate.

- **Bluebell to Fort Augustus:** A82 Onich lights; A82 Carrs Corner, Fort William, lights 09:30–16:00; A82 Loch Lochy emergency lights.
- **Fort Augustus to Pitlochry:** A82 Loch Lochy again; A86 lights at Ardverikie, and Kinloch Laggan to Laggan 05:30–19:00; A86 mobile lane closures.
- **A889 south of Catlodge:** closed for resurfacing, but only 19:00–06:00, so you'll be through well before then. If something delays you badly, the listed diversion is via the A9 and Kingussie.
- **A9 Dalnacardoch:** the listed lane closure is northbound; you're going south.

Walk: Fort Augustus locks to Loch Ness

About 1.9 km in all on the map, flat, on pavements and canalside paths. Allow 1 hour. Fort Augustus has a flight of five locks, with a footpath alongside. Toilets are listed at the canal and Canal Centre, but I couldn't confirm winter hours. The Lock Inn will have them at lunch.



P car park, 1 top of the locks (position estimated), 2 swing bridge on the A82, 3 Loch Ness viewpoint. North is up. Map © OpenStreetMap contributors.

1. Park in the village car park north of the river, 57.1467, -4.6820. One review says free parking; a camper listing for a canal car park mentions a QR code. Check the sign.
2. Walk back to the A82 and turn right, south, over the River Oich bridge on the pavement. Continue to the canal swing bridge, about 260 m in all.
3. Before the swing bridge, turn right along Canal Side, on the north bank. Follow the locks uphill for about 330 m to the top lock.
4. Turn round and walk back down to the swing bridge, looking into each lock.

5. Cross the road, and carry on along Canal Side with the canal on your right, about 380 m, to the Loch Ness viewpoint.
6. Walk back along Canal Side to the swing bridge. The Lock Inn is on the canal here, close to the bridge. Its exact position isn't on the map data I used.
7. After lunch, walk back over the River Oich bridge to the car, about 260 m.

For Noah to spot

- The five lock gates, and how much lower the water gets at each one
- The swing bridge, which turns to let boats through
- Fort Augustus lighthouse, on the far side of the canal mouth
- Nessie, of course
- Which way Loch Ness goes. It runs for over 20 miles from here.

Lunch: Lock Inn

01320 366302. Food all day per Visit Inverness Loch Ness. Older listings give 11:00–23:00 or 12:00–22:30, and I couldn't confirm November hours. Open fire, per its listings. **Phone before you leave Bluebell if you want to be sure.**

Fallbacks, hours not confirmed: The Boathouse, by the loch; Canalside Chip Shop; Cobb's Café.

Fonab Castle and the forest

- **Fonab:** the 1892 Grill's day menu runs until 16:30 or 17:00 (the official page shows both), and the Lounge Bar 12:00–18:00, so either works for the 16:00 snack.

- **The bus:** your tickets get scanned at check-in, then you queue for the next available bus.
- **Early dinner instead:** if Noah's flagging, eat before the forest and keep it light after.

If it rains or you run late

The forecast is dry.

- **Rain at Fort Augustus:** shorten to the swing bridge and the Loch Ness viewpoint, and go to the pub.
- **Running late:** the walk is the thing to cut. The fixed point is 17:15 at Fishers. Leave Fort Augustus by 13:30 at the latest, which gets you to Fonab about 15:30–15:45.

Not confirmed

- **The walk:** nobody has walked these directions. They're built from OpenStreetMap and the sources below, and distances are estimates. If a sign and these notes disagree, trust the sign.
- **Lock Inn:** November hours, and exact position.
- **Car park:** name and charge.
- **Fonab:** bed or cot for Noah, children's menu, and 20:00 table. The hotel's last-table time isn't published.
- **Fishers Hotel:** where to park for the forest bus.
- **Return time from the forest:** the trip notes say about 19:45–20:00; the ticket doesn't say.
- **Roadworks:** planned dates can change. Check again in the morning.

- **Drive times:** from a routing tool, without roadworks. My run gave 122 min from the village car park to Fonab, against 118 in the plan.

Numbers

- Lock Inn: 01320 366302
- Fonab Castle and 1892 Grill: 01796 470140
- Enchanted Forest order: 130768425
- Traffic Scotland care line: 0800 028 1414

Sources

Visit Inverness Loch Ness, Fort Augustus · Wikivoyage, Fort Augustus · CAMRA listing, Lock Inn · Scottish Canals, Fort Augustus · A889 closure · Roadworks · Forecast